

WOMEN'S 49KG VICTORY CEREMONY			
		OR	
	CHN 	HOU Zhihui	210 KG
	IND 	MIRABAI Chanu Saikhom	202 KG
	INA 	AISAH Windy Cantika	194 KG



Centre of attention: Mirabai was the toast of the country after her Tokyo win, but she and her coach knew from experience just how fleeting all that adulation can be. GETTYIMAGES

that my mother came to be with me in Patiala," she says. "At that point in time, I was feeling very low, but I also knew I had to stay there and continue my rehabilitation work. So I asked my mother if she could come and be with me. When your family is close, the mind feels a little relaxed. I felt I really needed her around me. I was so relaxed once she came."

Mirabai's mother, Saikhom Tombi Devi, came armed with a bucket of ingredients for Manipuri-style comfort food. "She made sure I ate home-cooked meals all the time. I have been at the national camp for more than a decade, and I have tried to make Manipuri-style food before.

But I never got the taste just right. I really missed Manipuri food. There is a dish called *erombi*, which has fish paste and is really spicy. I've tried to cook it myself, but it never tastes the same. But when my mother cooks for me and feeds me, it's a different feeling. It feels like everything is right in the world," she says.

Her emotional needs taken care of, her coach took charge of her physical improvements. "The one thing working in our favour was that Mira had already qualified for the Paris Olympics after winning a silver

at the 2022 World Championships. That meant we only had one mandatory competition to take part in (2024 World Cup). We could just focus on her recovery until then," he says.

"We knew that we couldn't train her lower body with weights. And you can't simulate Olympic-level weight training with bodyweight exercises. There's no substitute for the rod and weights. But we could use the time we had to work on strengthening all the small muscles — like the rotator cuffs in the

« The best thing that happened to me at that time [during rehab] was that my mother came to be with me in Patiala. When your family is close, the mind feels a little relaxed. I felt I really needed her around me. I was so relaxed once she came — Mirabai Chanu »